📄 Overview of ICT Accessibility in India

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In India, **Information and Communication Technology (ICT) accessibility** is primarily governed by the **Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016** and the detailed standards that have been established to implement this law. The goal is to ensure that everyone, including people with disabilities, can access and use digital products and services, such as websites, mobile apps, and other forms of electronic communication.

This framework is built on two main pillars:

- **Legal Mandate:** The RPwD Act, 2016, makes it a legal requirement for government and private entities to ensure their ICT is accessible.
- **Technical Standards:** The **Indian Standard (IS) 17802** and the **Guidelines for Indian Government Websites (GIGW)** provide the specific technical requirements and best practices for achieving compliance.

1. Legal Mandate: The RPwD Act, 2016

The RPwD Act is the foundation of digital accessibility in India. It legally obligates both government and private establishments to ensure their services, including ICT, are accessible.

- **Section 40** of the Act mandates the Central Government to formulate accessibility standards for information and communications, which led to the creation of the IS 17802 standard.
- **Section 42** requires that all content in audio, print, and electronic formats be made accessible. This includes providing **audio descriptions** and **captions** for electronic media and making daily use electronic goods universally designed.
- **Non-compliance** can lead to significant penalties, including fines for organizations that fail to meet these standards.

2. Technical Standards: IS 17802

The **Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS)** created the **IS 17802** standard, which is the key technical document for ICT accessibility. This standard is based on the European Standard **EN 301 549** and aligns with global benchmarks like **Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1 Level AA**. It is divided into two parts:

IS 17802 (Part 1): Requirements

This part outlines the specific requirements for making ICT products and services accessible. These requirements are based on the four core principles of accessibility, often referred to by the acronym **POUR**:

- **P**erceivable: Information and user interface components must be presentable to users in a way they can perceive.
  - **Text Alternatives**: All non-text content, such as images, charts, and diagrams, must have **alternative text** (alt text) so that it can be read by screen readers for users who are blind or have low vision.
  - **Captions & Transcripts**: All audio and video content must include **captions** for users with hearing impairments and **transcripts** for both audio and video content.
  - **Adaptable**: The content must be adaptable to different formats without losing information. For example, text should be resizable without breaking the layout.
- **O**perable: User interface components and navigation must be operable.
  - **Keyboard Navigation**: All functions and features must be fully usable with a keyboard alone, which is vital for people who cannot use a mouse due to motor impairments.
  - **Predictable Navigation**: The navigation system should be consistent and easy to follow.
  - **Enough Time**: Users should be given enough time to read and use the content. This includes controls to pause, stop, or hide moving or animated content.
- **U**nderstandable: The content and the operation of the user interface must be understandable.
  - **Readability**: Text should be clear and simple. When complex language is necessary, a glossary or simpler version should be provided.
  - **Predictable**: User interface components should behave in predictable ways. For example, a link should always lead to another page.
- **R**obust: The content must be robust enough to be reliably interpreted by a wide range of user agents, including assistive technologies.
  - **Compatibility**: The digital content should be compatible with different web browsers, operating systems, and assistive technologies like screen readers and screen magnifiers. This is achieved by using clean and valid code.

IS 17802 (Part 2): Determination of Conformance

This part of the standard specifies the **test procedures and evaluation methodologies** for

verifying that ICT products and services conform to the requirements outlined in Part 1. It provides guidance on how to create an **accessibility conformance report**, ensuring a standardized approach to auditing digital accessibility.

3. Guidelines for Indian Government Websites (GIGW)

The **Guidelines for Indian Government Websites (GIGW)** specifically apply to all government websites and apps. These guidelines also adopt the **WCAG 2.1 Level AA** as the primary accessibility standard. Key requirements under GIGW include:

- **Mandatory Accessibility:** All government websites must be accessible to people with disabilities.
- **Usability & Security:** Beyond accessibility, GIGW also sets standards for usability, ensuring that websites are easy to navigate and secure.
- **Multilingual Support:** As India is a multilingual country, the guidelines also encourage websites to be accessible in multiple Indian languages, wherever feasible.
- **Certification:** Websites are often audited by the **Standardisation Testing and Quality Certification (STQC) Directorate**, a body under the Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology, to ensure they meet GIGW standards. A certificate of compliance is a testament to the website's accessibility.